

2, Perceiving Classical Empires as "Towering Mountains" is a Universal Flaw of Humanity

Over a period of nearly two and a half years or even longer, I have indeed realized that regarding those who misjudged the developmental trajectory of human history—whether they be scholars or ordinary enthusiasts—the overwhelming majority were not necessarily blinded by deliberate propaganda. Rather, they projected far too many unrealistic illusions upon the **classical period** (古典时期).

If an individual merely fixates upon a single stage of human history, or exclusively focuses upon a specific region of the world, it genuinely becomes exceedingly difficult for them to escape this ideological trap. I myself was no exception; prior to the end of 2022, my comprehension of the **classical period** fundamentally did not differ from that of the majority of people worldwide. The radiance of **classical states** (古典国家) is simply too blinding, and their negative information has become difficult to attract attention due to chronological distance. Furthermore, the various phenomena of social "regression" during the early phase of **feudalization** (封建化) were exceptionally conspicuous. It would be one thing if it were merely urban decay or the shrinkage of the **commodity economy** (商品经济), yet deep down, I am acutely aware that for scholars in developed nations, certain phenomena involving "political correctness" (政治正确) are indeed difficult to address—such as the relative decline in the status of women.

The factual reality is that everyone under the sun, regardless of their ethnicity or nationality, inherently possesses a propensity for immediate gratification and rapid success. This is not surprising in the slightest, nor is it an egregiously terrible thing. Utilizing the minimal cost (*naturally including time cost*) to achieve maximum profit is a biological instinct; if any organism lacked this instinct, it ought to have gone extinct long ago.

From today's perspective, as long as one lacks comprehension of the developmental trajectory of human history, and fails to realize that a **classical society** (古典社会) fundamentally possesses zero possibility of evolving directly into a **modern society** (现代社会)—and that **feudal society** (封建社会) constitutes an insurmountable stage for developing modern civilization—it is phenomenally easy to fantasize: *If the classical empires had not collapsed, would the Scientific Revolution, the Age of Discovery, the Reformation, and bourgeois democracy have emerged prematurely?*

I can observe that academically trained scholars indeed remain vastly more cool-headed regarding this issue; at the very least, they can discern that the **classical period** was no utopian paradise, and that **feudal society**—even early **feudalization**—possesses historical significance. Yet even many highly prestigious scholars with monumental academic proficiency persistently fail to explicitly and straightforwardly affirm that the **classical period** existed merely as a transitional phase from an **early state** (早期国家) to a **feudal society**; and conversely, that **feudal society** holds decisive significance in the human developmental process. This remains the case even though it is blatantly obvious from a factual standpoint: regions like Northern Europe (北欧), which fundamentally never even experienced a **classical society**, are currently among the most developed parts of the Earth.

Analyzed from another perspective, although **feudalization** is decisive, it is ultimately not a panacea capable of resolving all problems. In regions with relatively harsh environmental conditions, such as the Ethiopian Highlands (埃塞俄比亚高原) and the Tibet (西藏) region, even if the **feudal system**

(封建制度) genuinely emerged, it could not generate substantial **surplus of social production** (社会生产剩余) available for technological investment; the meager surplus of social wealth was consumed merely maintaining the most fundamental circulation and public services of the society.

Feudalizing too late identically constituted a massive problem. Even if the **feudalization** process had commenced, provided the local society had not yet executed autonomous social reconstruction—meaning it had not reached the developmental level of the Late Middle Ages—then once Western influence began to manifest, the **feudalization** process in that region would inevitably experience an **ebb tide** (退潮). This does not refer to an essential historical reversal, but rather that **feudal characteristics** (封建因素) began to vanish. The communities at the grassroots level of society remained fragile, and the ideologies, consciousness, and organizations capable of resisting a despotic government remained immature. Yet, the **despotic power** (专制性权力) and **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) possessed by the state had already augmented via imported technological mechanisms; this obviously diverges astronomically from early modernization.

Within the Islamic world, South Asia, and Southeast Asia, **feudalization** frequently culminated in precisely this outcome. They indeed possessed the opportunity to progress further, but once the Europeans arrived, they could only lament, "The spirit is willing, but the flesh is weak" (“有心杀贼，无力回天” / *meaning possessing the ambition but lacking the capacity to alter the situation*).

Although I know committing such errors is normal, and I myself was certainly not immune to them initially, nowadays, whenever I think about the multitude of people across numerous global regions who still harbor illusions regarding **classical empires**, I cannot help but suppress a wry smile. It is perhaps forgivable for Chinese people to yearn for **classical empires**; after all, speaking frankly, China's historical trajectory veered drastically off course eons ago, and the populace has been subjected to thousands of years of deceptive propaganda, making deception unavoidable. It is not surprising for a French or German individual to feel nostalgic for Rome (罗马), but exactly what is the justification for lamenting the annihilation of Byzantium (拜占庭)?

Although phrasing it this way is highly offensive, from my perspective, it is perfectly normal for a resident of a developed European nation to feel nostalgic for the Roman Empire; however, if they lament Rome's annihilation and actively wish this empire had survived until today, it projects an absurd "aesthetic" (美感)—the aesthetic of an individual feeling discomfort in their knees simply because there is no emperor present for them to perform a kowtow (三拜九叩大礼). This is to say nothing of the fact that the ancestors of many residents of developed nations were precisely those barbarians (蛮族) who achieved extraordinary merits (殊勋) during the **feudalization** process; this essentially equates to obliterating the life's work of their own ancestors entirely from memory.

The nations surrounding China constitute an identical disaster zone regarding this perception. The Japanese fare slightly better. Although it remains highly comical that the Japanese—having been China's neighbor for twenty centuries—still possess a rather chaotic understanding of China's historical trajectory, Japan's geopolitical position is indeed genuinely exceptional. Whether within East Asia, where the tributary system of the Chinese empire once prevailed, or among modern developed nations that share relatively aligned values, Japan perpetually appears somewhat as an anomaly. Therefore, the Japanese somewhat incline toward emphasizing the exceptionality of their own national history and deeming it a matter of pride. As far as I know, many Daimyo (大名) from Japan's Sengoku period (战国时期) are regarded as local heroes.

The social cognition of South Korea and Vietnam appears exceedingly absurd even today: both nations attempt to emphasize certain cultures and traditions originating from China as their own cultures and traditions. I find it phenomenally bizarre: what exactly is so magnificent about these cultures and traditions that makes them cherish them so deeply? I have no desire to conceal this point: every time I encounter similar news in China—although there is invariably embellishment from the officialdom inciting nationalism—South Korea and Vietnam inevitably did *something* to trigger it.

I fundamentally fail to comprehend what exactly is worth fighting over regarding these traditional East Asian cultures. A cluster of **restoration-bureaucratic states** (复辟官僚国家)—surely no one genuinely believes they could produce anything of actual value! To me, South Korea and Vietnam resemble a slum dweller watching someone wander aimlessly through the slums, picking up someone else's garbage and treating it as treasure.

Their attitude toward Chinese characters (汉字) is identically thus: desiring to sever ties yet concurrently reluctant to do so, attempting to reap all the benefits, thereby generating numerous incidents that leave outsiders utterly speechless. Although, as a native speaker of Chinese, I naturally possess an emotional attachment to the Chinese language, for Korea and Vietnam, abolishing Chinese characters is by no means an unpardonable treason. According to the normal process of **feudalization** (封建化), they inherently ought to possess their own **vernacular languages** (封建民族语言) and scripts. This action possesses historical righteousness; the Chinese have zero justification to criticize it.

One wonders when Koreans and Vietnamese will finally realize that China's restoration-bureaucratic empire and its tributary system (朝贡体系) were an astonishing catastrophe for the entire periphery of China. Since they are already independent, maintaining a respectful distance from these historical issues would suffice; insisting on leaning into them genuinely appears profoundly unwise. Even as a Chinese individual, I must concede that the "**Towering Mountains**" (重冈俊阜) might actually possess some dark magic, capable of making both Koreans and Vietnamese believe that "Little China" ("小中华") is a complimentary term.

The Korean attitude toward the Ming Dynasty (明朝) is, from my perspective, identically a highly comical topic. It is alleged that even in present-day South Korea, there are individuals who believe the Ming Dynasty bestowed the "grace of profound reconstruction" (再造之恩) upon Korea. I find it unfathomable that *Sadaejui* (事大主义 / Flunkeyism) still exists in the 21st century.

The Koreans truly epitomize knowing only the surface but not the essence. They astutely perceived the reality that without Ming intervention, they would have struggled to survive Toyotomi Hideyoshi's (丰臣秀吉) invasion, yet they were insufficiently astute to perceive exactly what caused Korea to be beaten to a pulp by Japan. A unified Japan was definitively stronger than Korea at that time; however, whether measured by population or converted into Japan's Kokudaka system (石高制), Korea's sheer mass equated to more than half of Japan. Furthermore, Toyotomi Hideyoshi did not mobilize every Daimyo (大名) across Japan to participate in the war; he prioritized dispatching his own direct affiliates for expansion. How could he possibly not retain some defense against the Daimyo of Eastern Japan?

Thus, the forces committed to the war by both sides should theoretically have been roughly equivalent. The Japanese army had to execute a trans-marine expedition, and the Korean Peninsula

is hardly flat terrain; why, then, did they lose so catastrophically? The core reason lies in the fact that the Joseon Dynasty of Korea (朝鮮李朝) was identically a **restoration-bureaucratic regime** (官僚复辟政权). The Ming Emperor and the Korean King genuinely achieved mutually beneficial extraction within the tributary system: "*Rulers of restoration-bureaucratic states, unite.*" Both sides provided legitimacy for each other's despotic bureaucratic rule domestically. Naturally, relatively speaking, the assistance provided by the Ming Dynasty to the Korean King was unquestionably greater.

Koreans never reflect upon the fact that their historical trajectory possessed no manifest disparities with Japan's between the 5th and 12th centuries—perhaps even possessing a certain advantage. How did it devolve into such a state by the end of the 16th century? If Korea had undergone normal **feudalization** identically to Japan, upon what basis could Toyotomi Hideyoshi covet Korea? A nation commanding over ten million *koku* (石), bristling with mountain fortresses, requiring a trans-marine conquest—and geographically speaking, this nation's cavalry might even be superior, as objective disparities in equine quality indeed existed. Would Korea still need to obsequiously beg China for military assistance as it did in actual history?

This entire affair is inherently highly comical: the Koreans themselves embarked upon a dead end under Chinese influence, and consequently, upon encountering feudal Japan, they could only rely upon China to dispatch troops and utilize sheer mass advantage to temporarily repel Japan. Three hundred years later, when China could no longer defeat Japan even relying on mass, the Korean Peninsula was annexed by Japan. The process is so glaringly lucid; I fundamentally cannot discern a single reason why ordinary Korean citizens should feel gratitude toward the Ming Dynasty. Conversely, they possess ten thousand reasons to despise this despotic empire.

The Korean King would naturally express gratitude to the Ming Dynasty, uttering phrases like "never forgetting the grace of profound reconstruction for all eternity"—but what does this have to do with an ordinary Korean commoner? The existence of the Ming Dynasty undeniably benefited the Korean rulers overall, but did the Korean people benefit? Today, South Korea is, at the very least, one of the few developed nations in Asia, and by Asian standards, an exceptionally fine democratic state. Do some ordinary citizens genuinely still believe that a despotic monarch can represent their interests?

From this, it is evident that the average intelligence of peoples across the globe likely possesses zero disparity. As the Chinese saying goes, "When the forest is large enough, it holds every kind of bird" (林子大了什么鸟都有). The precise reason the behaviors of birds in certain forests exhibit universal characteristics is exclusively dictated by the structural nature of the forest itself.

Alas, although it sounds phenomenally ludicrous for an individual living in China to contemplate the destiny of all humanity—after all, my motherland ostensibly perished the exact moment the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) was **restored** fourteen centuries ago—I still wish to record my anxieties here. Those who read this and wish to mock me, feel free to do so!

According to my observations, geographically speaking, the epicenter of human civilization has undergone three colossal shifts throughout the entire historical period: **The Great Expansion** (大扩张), **feudalization** (封建化), and the Age of Discovery alongside the Industrial Revolution. Perhaps this observation qualifies as a truism, but no one can deny that during all three shifts, the newly ascendant regions were invariably former peripheries of civilization. This perhaps reflects a certain

predicament in the development of human civilization: when a society becomes excessively mature at a specific stage, it indeed—either subjectively (*by certain strata*) or inadvertently—manufactures numerous obstacles impeding the march toward the subsequent historical stage. Consequently, it is invariably the peripheral regions, subjected to fewer hindrances, that manage to secure the advantage.

Thus, we confront a predicament of the contemporary world: progress ostensibly has "nowhere to go." First, the planet we inhabit has been exhaustively explored; every tract of land is meticulously mapped, and even indigenous tribes within rainforests have begun to experience the impact of modern civilization. There is fundamentally nowhere left to spawn a "new periphery." Second, having undergone the filtration of several societal stage developments, provided history has not reached its conclusion, the nations currently capable of participating in the competition for the next societal stage can be counted on one's fingers—merely twenty or thirty developed nations.

We indeed observed that during *The Great Expansion* and the *feudalization* periods, certain locales were capable of executing leapfrog development, overtaking the former epicenters of civilization in a single stride. The Aryans (雅利安人) of Iran experienced an exceedingly brief *early state* (早期国家) stage before swelling into a *classical empire* (古典帝国); Central and Northern Europe fundamentally bypassed the *classical period* (古典时代) entirely and plunged directly into *feudal society* (封建社会).

However, those events are already historically remote. By the time Europeans commenced their march toward the *early modern period* (近世), the disparities in the developmental processes of various global regions had already become far too colossal. Without completely experiencing a *feudal society*, a non-colonial nation fundamentally cannot enter an *early modern society* (近世社会); without traversing an *early modern society*, a non-colonial nation identically cannot enter a *modern society* (现代社会). Ideological emancipation and the Scientific Revolution altered the morphology of preceding societies far too profoundly. Today, I fear no one could conceivably believe that a nation, region, or ethnicity capable of leading the future historical development of humanity could somehow fail to have universally adopted modern values; I myself certainly do not believe it.

In the 21st century, it is genuinely phenomenally difficult to expect a *pseudo-modernized* (伪近/现代化) region—one that merely belongs to a *modern society* on the superficial level sculpted by technology, but whose fundamental essence remains stagnated at some indistinguishable past epoch—to suddenly march to the absolute vanguard of human civilization via leapfrog development and hoist the banner of global leadership. Yet, where can Western nations and Japan look to find a new frontier?

Even though the history of the United States over its more than two centuries has indeed generated myriad miracles, and I concede it is a magnificent nation, I identically refuse to believe that any nation on earth can flourish eternally without decline. Who is capable of succeeding the position of the United States? In the past, many people assumed it would be China, but I can state with absolute clarity that this is unequivocally impossible; such a scenario would be indistinguishable from the direct annihilation of human civilization.

Among the developed nations, can the historically secondary powers like Britain, France, Germany, and Japan shoulder this burden? Europeans once led the world; could they genuinely lead it once

more? Or is the United States genuinely capable of executing a "self-revolution" and enduring far longer? Or perhaps, in the future, a genuine united global government will emerge on Earth; but exactly how would this "Earth State" resolve the colossal developmental disparities among its various constituent parts? Or perhaps adventurers like Elon Musk (埃隆·马斯克) indeed possess a valid point: stop fixating exclusively on this trivial plot of land called Earth—if we can land on Mars, wouldn't a new peripheral region materialize immediately! However, standing at the chronological vantage point of 2025, large-scale extraterrestrial migration ostensibly remains far too remote.

During a conversation with B at the beginning of 2025, we identically touched upon this matter; after concluding the topic, we laughed for a prolonged period. After all, no matter how one looks at it, this topic equates to us worrying on behalf of the West and Japan. However, I subsequently felt that the situation might be nowhere near this pessimistic. We are currently living *within* the ongoing historical process, making it indeed phenomenally difficult to judge exactly where this river of history is surging toward. When *feudalization* had merely just commenced back then, the intellectuals of Western Europe and Japan universally wailed in agony that the heavens were collapsing. Yet, gazing back upon that era after the passage of a millennium, the precise location upon which they stood was exactly the starting point from which the *Oikumene* ultimately achieved tranquility and prosperity.

2，将古典帝国视为“重冈俊阜”是全人类的通病

在将近两年半甚至更久的时间里，我的确意识到对于那些误判了人类历史发展进程的人，无论是学者还是普通的爱好者，绝大多数也并不是被有益的宣传所蒙蔽，而是对于古典时期寄予了太多不切实际的幻想。如果一个人仅仅是盯着人类历史的一个阶段，或者是只关注世界上的某一个区域，那他真的很难逃脱这种思想陷阱。我自己也不例外，在 2022 年年终之前，我对于古典时代的认识跟世界上大部分人也没有区别。古典国家的光辉太过耀眼，那些负面的信息因为年代久远已经难以引起人们的注意。封建化早期的各种社会“退步”的现象又特别明显，如果说仅仅是城市衰退，商品经济萎缩这些也就罢了，然而我其实心里也知道对于发达国家的学者来说，有些涉及“政治正确”问题的现象的确不好说，就如女性地位相对下降。

事实就是，天底下所有人，无论是属于什么民族，什么国家，或多或少都会有急功近利的倾向。这一点也不奇怪，而且不是多么糟糕的坏事，用最小的成本，当然也包括时间成本，去取得最大的收益是生物的本能，要是哪个生物没有这种本能那它早该灭绝了。站在今天的角度，只要对于人类历史发展进程不了解，没有意识到古典社会绝不存在直接向现代社会演变的可能，封建社会是发展出近现代文明不可越过的阶段，那就很容易幻想如果没有古典帝国的崩溃，科学革命，地理大发现，宗教改革和资产阶级民主这些事物会不会提前出现。我能看到科班出身的学者在这个问题上的确会冷静很多，最起码能够看出古典时代并非王道乐土，封建社会，哪怕是封建化早期也存在历史意义。可即使是很多学术水平极高，颇具名望的学者也总是不能直截了当地肯定古典时期仅仅作为一个早期国家到封建社会的过渡期存在，反之封建社会在人类发展历程中具有决定性。哪怕这一点在事实上看是如此的显而易见：像北欧这种根本没经历过古典社会的地区现在却是地球上最发达的部分之一。

从另一个方面来说，封建化虽然具有决定性，但是毕竟不是解决一切问题的灵丹妙药。在环境条件比较恶劣的地方，比如埃塞俄比亚高原和西藏地区，就是出现了真出现了封建制度也产生不了多少可以用于技术投资的社会生产剩余，少量富余的社会财富也被用来维持这个社会最基本的流通和公共服务。封建化太晚也是一个问题，就算封建化进程已经展开，但是只要本地社会没有自行的社会重构这一步，即达

不到中世纪晚期的发展水平。那么当西方影响开始出现之后，该地区的封建化进程就会出现退潮，这不是指一种本质上的历史逆流，而是封建因素开始消失了。社会基层的共同体仍然薄弱，能够对抗专制政府的思想、意识和组织都不成熟，但国家所拥有的专制性权力以及基础性权力已经通过舶来的技术手段增长了，这显然跟近现代化相去甚远。在伊斯兰世界，南亚和东南亚，封建化往往以这种结局告终，它们的确有机会走得更远，但是欧洲人一来就只能“有心杀贼，无力回天”。

虽然我知道犯这样的错误是正常的，我一开始也不是没有犯过这样的错误，但是我现在只要一想到世界上的许多地方的许多人都依然对于古典帝国抱有幻想，就会忍俊不禁。要说中国人怀念古典帝国也就罢了，毕竟说实话中国的历史进程早就偏到没边，而且百姓又受了上千年的欺骗性宣传，上当也是没办法的事。一个法国人或者德国人怀念罗马不奇怪，可是为拜占庭的灭亡感到惋惜算怎么回事呢？虽然这样说十分冒犯，但是在我看来，一个欧洲发达国家的居民怀念罗马帝国是正常的，但是如果为罗马的灭亡感到惋惜并且希望这个帝国延续至今，那就有一种因为没有皇帝能够行三拜九叩的大礼而感到膝盖不舒服的“美感”。更不要一些很多发达国家居民的祖先就是那些在封建化中立有殊勋的蛮族，这属于把祖宗平生功业给忘到一干二净了。中国周边国家也是这种认识的重灾区。日本人还好一点，虽然日本人作为中国二十个世纪的邻居对于中国的历史进程认识仍相当混沌这一点就很好笑了。但是日本所处的位置确实太过特殊，无论是在中华帝国朝贡体系存在的亚洲东部，还是在现代具有比较一致价值观的发达国家中，它总是显得有些异类。因此日本人多少会倾向于强调本国历史的特殊性并认为这是一件自豪的事，据我所知很多日本战国时期的大名都被视为乡土英雄。

韩国和越南的社会认知即使在今天仍然看起来很离谱：这两个国家都试图把来自中国的一些文化和传统强调成是自己的文化和传统。我十分奇怪，这些文化和传统到底是什么好东西让他们这么喜欢？我不想隐瞒这一点，每次在中国看到类似的新闻，尽管总有官方煽动民族主义的添油加醋在，但是韩国和越南总归是做了什么。我非常搞不明白这些东亚的传统文化到底有什么好争的？一群复辟官僚国家，不会真的有人觉得他们能生产出什么好东西吧！我看韩国和越南就如同一个贫民窟里的居民看到有人在贫民窟瞎转，把别人的垃圾捡来当宝贝一样。他们对于汉字的态度也是如此，既想划清关系又不想划清关系，什么好处都想占，因此整出来的很多事情让外人看了很无语。虽然我作为汉语的母语使用者对汉语肯定有感情，但是对于朝鲜和越南来说，废除汉字并非大逆不道，按照封建化的正常进程，本来他们就应该有自己的民族语言和文字，这件事是有历史正义性的，中国人没有理由对此说三道四。也不知道韩国人和越南人什么时候才能意识到中国的复辟官僚帝国还有朝贡体系对于整个中国周边地区都是一个惊人的祸害，既然已经独立，对于这些历史问题敬而远之即可，非要往前凑实在是显得不聪明。即使作为中国人我都不得不承“重冈俊阜”搞不好真有什么魔力，能让朝鲜人和越南人都认为“小中华”是什么好词。

朝鲜人对于明朝的态度在我看来也是一个颇具笑料的话题。据称在现在的韩国还有人认为明朝对于朝鲜有再造之恩，我难以想象都21世纪了还有“事大主义”。朝鲜人真可谓是只知其一不知其二，他们聪明地看到了没有明朝干预自己难以在丰臣秀吉的侵略中幸存的事实，但是又不够聪明以至于没有看到是什么原因导致朝鲜被日本打得落花流水。一个统一的日本在当时强于朝鲜是肯定的，但是无论是从人口还是换算成日本的石高制来看，朝鲜的体量相当于大半个日本。再加上丰臣秀吉又不是让全日本的大名都参战，他也是优先派遣自己的嫡系进行扩张，怎么可能对于东日本大名没有一点防备。这样双方投入战争的力量按道理是基本持平的，日军需要渡海远征，朝鲜半岛也并非什么一马平川的地形，为何输成那个样子？原因在于朝鲜李朝也是一个官僚复辟政权，大明皇帝和朝鲜国王在朝贡体系中真正做到了各取所需，“复辟官僚国家的统治者联合起来”。双方互相为对方在国内进行专制官僚统治提供合法性，当然相对而言，肯定是明朝对于朝鲜国王的帮助更大。

朝鲜人从来不想想自己跟日本的历史进程从 5 到 12 世纪间都没什么明显差别，甚至还有一定的优势，怎么到了 16 世纪末就成了这个样子？如果朝鲜也和日本一样正常封建化，丰臣秀吉凭什么覬觎朝鲜啊？一个一千多万石的，山城林立的，还需要渡海征服的国家，甚至从地理上看，这个国家的骑兵可能更强一些，毕竟马的质量差异是客观存在的。朝鲜还需要像历史上那样低三下四地向中国求援吗？这件事情本来就是非常搞笑的，朝鲜人自己在中国的影响下走上死路，然后遇到封建日本的时候只能让中国出兵凭借体量优势暂时击退日本。等到三百年后中国即使凭借体量也难以击败日本，朝鲜半岛就被日本吞并了。过程这么清楚，我是根本看不出来朝鲜老百姓有什么需要感激明朝的地方，反而有一万个理由去憎恨这个专制帝国。朝鲜国王当然会感激明朝说什么“永世不忘再造之恩”这样的话，但是这和一个普通的朝鲜百姓有什么关系？明朝的存在确实总体上让朝鲜统治者受益，朝鲜人民受益了吗？今天韩国好歹也是一个亚洲屈指可数的发达国家，而且以亚洲的标准来看已经是非常好的民主国家了，居然真的还有老百姓认为专制君主能代表自己的利益吗？由此可见世界各国人民的平均智商恐怕就没什么差异，如同中国人说的“林子大了什么鸟都有”。之所以一些林子中鸟的行为具有一些普遍的特征，这无非是由林子的性质决定的。

唉，虽然一个在中国生活的人考虑全人类的命运这件事听起来就滑稽可笑，毕竟我的祖国在十四个世纪前官僚国家复辟的那一刻就可以说亡了。但是我还是想在这里写下我的忧虑，看到的人如果想笑话就随意吧！

据我观察，从地理上看人类文明的中心在整个历史时期发生过三次大的转移，即大扩张，封建化和地理大发现及工业革命。或许这件事情属于老生常谈，但是谁都难以否认三次转移中新崛起的地区都是曾经的文明边缘。这或许反映了人类文明发展的某种困境，当一个社会在某一个阶段已经过于成熟，它的确主观地（一些阶层主观地）或者无意地已经制造了许多迈向下一个历史阶段的障碍，因此总是受到阻碍较少的边缘地区能够取得优势。于是这样一来我们看到了当代世界的一个困境：进步似乎“无处可去”了。首先是我们生活的这个星球已经被探索完毕，每一片陆地都清清楚楚，甚至连雨林中的原始部落也开始受到现代文明的影响，没有哪里能产生“新的边缘”。其次是经过社会阶段发展的几次过滤，那么只要历史没有终结，现在能够参加到竞争下一个社会阶段的国家已经屈指可数，就那么二三十个发达国家罢了。我们的确看到在大扩张时期和封建化时期，一些地方能够实现跳跃式发展一举反超曾经作为文明核心的区域。伊朗的雅利安人仅仅经历了非常短暂的早期国家阶段就膨胀成为古典帝国，中欧和北欧根本不需要经历古典时代就进入了封建社会。

但是那些事情都已经遥远，当欧洲人开始走向近世的时候，这个世界不同地方发展进程相差之间已经太大。不完整经历封建社会，非殖民地国家不可能进入近世社会；没有经过近世社会，非殖民地国家也不可能进入现代社会。思想解放和科学革命太过深远地改变了以往社会的面貌，现在恐怕没有人能够相信在未来能够引领人类历史发展的国家或者地方或者民族却连现代价值观都未能普及，我自己也不相信这一点。在 21 世纪，我们真的很难指望一个仅仅在技术所塑造的表面上属于现代社会，但其本质上还不知道停在何处的伪近代化地区通过跳跃式发展一下走到人类文明的前列，举起领导世界的旗帜。但西方国家和日本又能够将哪里视为新的边疆呢？即使美国迄今为止两个多世纪的历史确实创造了很多奇迹，我也承认这是一个伟大的国家，但我也不会相信世界上有任何一个国家能长盛不衰。谁能够接替美国的位置？过去很多人认为是中国，但我可以很明确地说绝对不可能，那种情况跟直接毁灭人类文明没什么区别。在发达国家中，原本处于次一级地位的英、法、德、日能挑起这副担子吗？欧洲人曾经领导过世界，他们难道还能再领导一次吗？还是说美国真的能“自我革命”坚持得更为长久呢？又或者将来地球上会出现一个真正的联合政府，但是这个“地球国”又怎么解决自身各个部分发展进程千差万别的问题？又

或者埃隆马斯克这样的冒险家的确有其道理，不要再盯着地球这一亩三分地了，如果能够登陆火星，新的边缘地区不就马上出现了嘛！但是站在 2025 年这个时间点，大规模移民外星似乎还太过遥远。

B 在 25 年初有一次跟我聊天的时候也谈到了这件事情，我们说完之后笑了好久，毕竟这个话题怎么看都是替西方和日本操心。不过我后来觉得事情可能远远没这么悲观，我们生活在当下的历史进程中，的确很难判断历史这条河流将奔向何处。当年封建化刚刚开始的时候，西欧和日本的知识分子无不痛呼天下将倾，但是在千百年后的今天回望当年，他们所站立的位置正是天下平定的起点。